

BULLDOZER AT THE GATES A madrassa being demolished at Bongaigaon, Assam, Aug. 31

accused the BJP of terrorising Muslims by "interfering in the functioning of private madrassas" operating on "*qaum ke chande* (community donations)".

All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen chief Asaduddin Owaisi was more articulate in his remonstrations, citing Article 30 of the Constitution, which says that the minorities have a fundamental right to set up educational institutions of their choice. "Madrassas have come up as per Article 30, so why has the UP government ordered a survey? This is just a mini NRC (the controversial National Register of Citizens). They just want to harass Muslims," he says.

Muslim scholars in the state are divided over the surveys. Maulana Arshad Madani, principal of the renowned Darul Uloom in Deoband, sees nothing wrong in it. "There are no illegal activities at the madrassas. If any madrassa has been constructed illegally, we have no problem if the government demolishes it," he said on September 18.

The All India Muslim Personal Law Board (AIMPLB), though, questions the UP government's motives. "Minority institutions are being targeted even though they are protected under the law. If the issue is restricting religious education and promoting a secular model, then why isn't the government taking action against RSS-run gurukuls?" asks Qasim Rasool Ilyas, executive member, AIMPLB.

TROUBLE IN THE HILLS

Meanwhile, in Assam, a nearly five-decade-long history of agitations over illegal Bangladeshi immigrants has now metamorphosed into a Hindu-Muslim conflict. And madrassas are the latest points of contention. In the past two months, local authorities have demolished three of them, in the Morigaon, Barpeta and Bongaigaon districts, respectively. On paper, they were illegal constructions, but insiders claim they were being probed for links to terror outfits like Al Qaeda in the Indian Subcontinent (AQIS) and the Bangladesh-based Ansarullah Bangla Team (ABT).

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma says Assam is becoming a "hotbed" of Islamist radicals, with "jihadists" masquerading as imams or teachers in madrassas. Since February, the Assam Police have arrested 36 people, including two imams and three madrassa teachers allegedly involved in carrying out financial transactions for the ABT. The National Investigation Agency has made another four arrests. The air has become so vitiated that on September 6, locals took matters into their own hands and razed a madrassa in Goalpara district for alleged jihadi links.

ASSAM HAS ALREADY RAZED THREE MADRASSAS, ALLEGING TERROR LINKS

However, questions are also being raised on the intent of the BJP-led state government. Calling the bulldozer action a political stunt to garner Hindu votes, Lok Sabha MP and All India United Democratic Front (AIUDF) chief Badruddin Ajmal says the Sarma government was trying to instil fear among the Muslims, who constitute 35 per cent of the state's population. "There may be some anti-social elements in the community and the government should act against them. But using a bulldozer on a madrassa is unacceptable," says Ajmal, who also heads a private board that runs 1,000-odd madrassas in the state. He is now planning to move the Supreme Court if the drive continues.

The state government is in no mood to relent. CM Sarma has asserted that madrassas will continue to face the "strictest action" if used for "anti-India activities". The Assam Police believe the drive has helped nip the Islamic terror threat in the bud. "Our actions will push back radicalisation and indoctrination by several years," says G.P. Singh, special DGP, Assam Police.

Not many are convinced that such drastic action will have good results. SP spokesperson Zeba Yasmeen says, "The BJP had enough time, eight years at the Centre and six years in UP, but we didn't see a single madrassa-focused reform. In fact, even the promised salaries of registered teachers (from 2017) have not come. Is it wrong then to have apprehensions about their intent?" With the bulldozers at the gates, it seems there's only one loser in this battle. ■